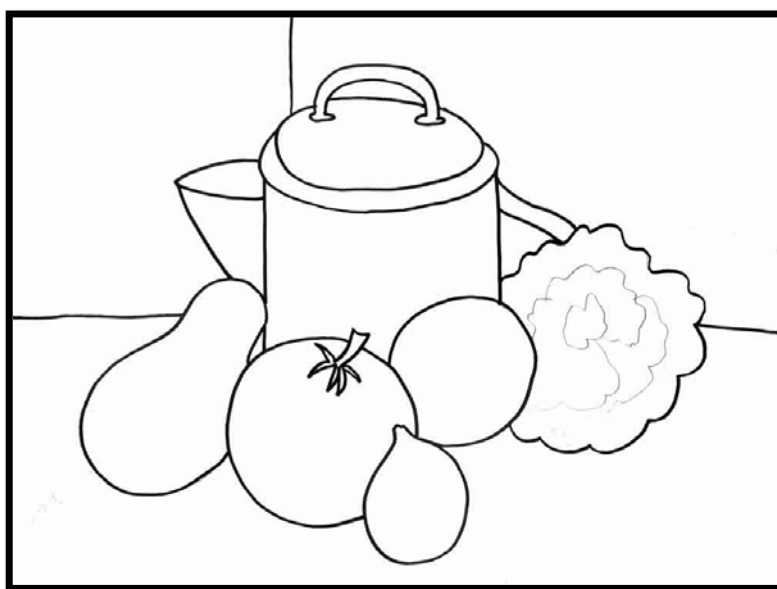




Drawing Still Life

Grade 6
Drawing



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Last Revised: February 2023

DRAWING STILL LIFE

Length: 60 minutes

Number of docents: 1

Purpose:

- To use observational drawing skills to depict a still life.
- To have students further their knowledge of composition and pattern.

Visual Arts Standards:

- Formulate an artistic investigation of personally relevant content for creating art. (6.VA:Cr1.2)
- Demonstrate openness in trying new ideas, materials, methods, and approaches in making works of art and design. (6.VA:Cr2.1)
- Reflect on whether personal artwork conveys the intended meaning and revise accordingly. (6.VA:Cr3)

Unit Contains: Supply box and portfolio

Materials docent will bring per student:

- 11”x 15” sheets of watercolor paper
- Fine and Extra Fine Sharpies
- White erasers
- Objects to create a still life for the class (coffee pot, solid color tablecloth, assorted artificial fruits and vegetables in lesson box)
- Principles of Design poster

Materials teacher will provide per student:

- Pencil

Featured works:

Fruit and Jug on a Table, c. 1890-94
Still Life with Vases and Fish, 1958
Festive Table, 1986
Nature Morte à L’Ananas, 1988
Still Life, 1996
Untitled (Six Works), c. 1998

Paul Cezanne
Francis Newton Souza
Raymond Han
Fernando Botero
Yayoi Kusama
Ana Mercedes Hoyos

SETTING UP THE STILL LIFE

Arrange a still life in the front of the classroom within view of all students. Elevate the display using the lesson box turned on its side or a few large books. Cover the base with a tablecloth. Add coffee pot and 5 more fruits or vegetables in different sizes and in primary & secondary colors. Take care not to get the arrangement too busy.

Give each student one sheet of 11” x 15” watercolor paper and eraser.

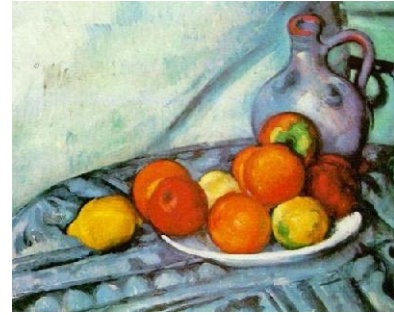
INTRODUCTION (5 minutes)

Fruit and Jug on a Table, c. 1890-94

Paul Cezanne

Oil on canvas

13" x 16"



A still life is a painting featuring an arrangement of inanimate, everyday objects typically on a table. Still life paintings have been around since the ancient times and done in many different artistic styles. Here is an example of a still life by Paul Cezanne.

- *What is the focal point of this painting?*
- *What does your eye move to next?*
- *In this still life, which item is in the back? Why do you think that? (overlapping)*

Display other still life paintings on board with Principles of Design poster:



Composition is the placement or arrangement of the elements in a painting. Composition uses the elements of art (line, shape, space, texture and color) as well as the principles of design to create meaning in an artwork. Let's look at some additional paintings to see if we can identify some of the things that create a good composition in a still life painting.

- **Balance** – the distribution of the visual weight of objects, colors, texture, and space. Balance can be symmetrical or asymmetrical.
 - *Which of these paintings have symmetrical balance? Are any asymmetrical?*
- **Emphasis** – part of the design that catches the viewer's attention.
 - Point to a painting and ask, "*What is the focal point of this painting?*"
- **Movement** – the path the viewer's eye takes through the painting.
 - Which still life has the most movement?
- **Pattern/Repetition/Rhythm** – Pattern is repeating of an object or symbol. Rhythm is created when one or more elements of design are used repeatedly
 - *Which painting has the most pattern? Repetition? Rhythm?*
- **Proportion** – when all the parts of the painting relate well with each other
 - *Do you see proportion in any of these still lifes?*
- **Variety** – the use of several elements of design to create interest
 - *Which painting has the most variety?*
- **Unity** – a feeling of harmony between all parts
 - *Which painting has the most unity? Why?*

OBSERVATIONAL DRAWING

Although we are all doing an observational drawing today, you each as artists can make decisions that will affect the composition of your piece. Here is an example of the same still life from different angles like you will have.



You will be able to make some composition choices with your drawing.

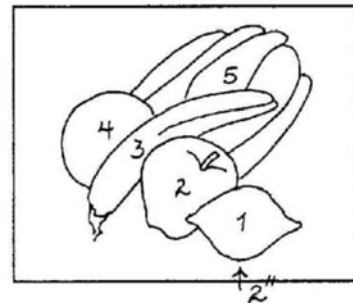
- Will your subject be in the middle of the paper or off to one side?
- You can be closer or further away from the still life but remember to draw the fruits and vegetables rather large so you have something to paint in the next lesson.

Have the students look carefully at the still life.

- Which object is closest to you?
- Which one is farthest away?
- Compare sizes of different fruits and vegetables using terms like half as big, quarter of the size, twice as big.
 - How large is the lemon compared to the apple?

On a sheet of paper, demonstrate how to sketch a still life. Students will create their still life after the demonstration. Let them know that part two will be adding color and pattern to their drawing.

1. Take a minute or so to study the still life before you start to draw your observational drawing.



- We will draw lightly with a pencil. Try to avoid erasing because watercolor works best on paper that has not been heavily erased. Ask them to use their finger first on the paper to “draw” their composition and get an idea of where objects should go and how large they should be or to draw them in the air to get an idea of making them large.
- Start with the object closest to you. Draw the first object at least two inches (two or three fingers away) from the bottom of the paper.
- Look at the outline of the object and draw what you see----contour line drawing---let your eyes walk around the outline of the object and draw that outline.
- Draw the object adjacent to the first object and then add adjoining objects working to the sides, and up the paper until the composition is complete. Keeping

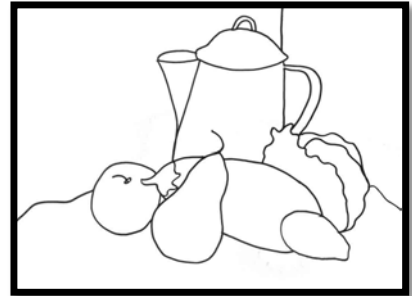
in mind the relative size of each of the items (Should it be larger or smaller than the object next to it?)

- **THINK BIG! Objects should be as large as your fist to provide ample space for painting.**
- Add a minimum of detail with the pencil. Detail will be added later when you paint.

Give students 15-20 minutes of drawing time and then move on.

2. Divide the surrounding space into three areas: a foreground to show where your still life is sitting and a background divided into two sections.

- Foreground can be shown with a diagonal, curved, or horizontal line.
 - The background line is vertical. Do not place it in the center of the paper or behind the largest element in the drawing. The two spaces will be more aesthetically pleasing if they are not the same size.
3. Check the composition.
- Is it balanced? Is it pleasing to your eye?



INKING

Have students outline with Sharpie the contour lines of their drawing.

- Contour lines are the basic outlines, leave lots of room for painting.
- Point out that the thicker the line, the more it stands out and that not everything needs to be outlined
- Encourage them to avoid marking in small detail; it will make the painting look too black.



NOTES:

- **If any students are absent for the lesson, please leave a piece of watercolor paper and ask the teacher to allow some time for the student to make it up**

- before the Watercolor lesson. You can suggest the teacher take a photo of the still life composition for the absent student to draw.**
- **Please put your drawing in the Watercolor Still Life unit so the Watercolor docent can use it for the painting lesson. Write the teacher's name and "Docent Copy" on the back.**

BACKGROUND

FERNANDO BOTERO, b. 1932 (Colombian)

Fernando Botero Angulo is a Colombian figurative artist and sculptor, born in Medellín. His signature style, also known as "Boterismo", depicts people and figures in large, exaggerated volume, which can represent political criticism or humor, depending on the piece.

Nature Morte à L'Ananas, 1988

Oil on canvas

57 ½" x 78"

RAYMOND HAN, 1931-2017 (American Korean)

Born in Honolulu, HA of Korean descent, Raymond Han studied at the Arts Student League of New York. Han lived and worked in upstate New York for the last period of his working life. He was best known for his still lifes in the photorealism genre, but also incorporated the human figure as well as abstraction into his compositions.

Festive Table, 1986

Oil on canvas

51" x 51"

ANA MERCEDES HOYOS, 1942-2014 (Colombian)

Ana Mercedes Hoyos was a Colombian painter, sculptor and a pioneer in modern art in the country. In her half-century of artistic works, she garnered over seventeen awards of national and international recognition. Beginning her career in a Pop Art style which moved towards abstract, her trajectory moved toward cubism and realism as she explored light, color, sensuality and the bounty of her surroundings. Through her still lifes, Hoyos came to appreciate Afro-Columbian heritage, transitioning from an admiration of beauty of the lush bounty to an appreciation of cultural contributions and multicultural diversity of the people that populated Colombia.

Untitled (Six Works), 1998

Oil on canvas

Each is 25" x 25"

YAYOI KUSAMA, b. 1929 (Japanese)

Yayoi Kusama is a Japanese contemporary artist who works primarily in sculpture and installation, and is also active in painting, performance, video art, fashion, poetry, fiction, and other arts. Her work is based in conceptual art and shows some attributes of feminism, minimalism, surrealism, Art Brut, pop art, and abstract expressionism, and is infused with autobiographical, psychological, and sexual content. She has been acknowledged as one of the most important living artists to come out of Japan, the world's top-selling female artist, and the world's most successful living artist. Her work influenced that of her contemporaries, including Andy Warhol and Claes Oldenburg.

Still Life, 1996

Acrylic on canvas
14" x 18"

FRANCIS NEWTON SOUZA, 1924-2002 (Indian)

Francis Newton Souza was one of the first painters to achieve international recognition from a newly independent India, as well as a leading figure of its avant-garde movement. As a result of his time spent abroad, Souza's style drew heavily from Expressionism and ArtBrut. Often referred to as the "Indian Picasso", Souza became known for his aggressive lines and thick application of color. He was fascinated with images of the sacred and the profane, and the boundary that divided them. His favorite subjects included the human figure, frequently depicted engaging in erotic acts and organized rituals of religion. Souza was also responsible for co-founding the Bombay Progressive Artist's Group in 1947, which sought to encourage artist to depict Indian subject matter with Western Modern styles.

Still Life with Vases and Fish, 1958
Oil on canvas
29" x 48"

PAUL CEZANNE, 1839-1906 (French)

The work of Post-Impressionist French painter Paul Cézanne, born in Aix-en-Provence in 1839, can be said to have formed the bridge between late 19th century Impressionism and the early 20th century's new line of artistic inquiry, Cubism. The mastery of design, tone, composition and color that spans his life's work is highly characteristic of his style. He spent a large part of his career on still life paintings. Both Henri Matisse and Pablo Picasso were greatly influenced by Cézanne.

Fruit and Jug on a Table, c. 1890-94
Oil on canvas
12 ¾" x 16"

Museum of Fine Arts Boston

Every stroke in this rather small painting has been carefully calibrated to every other stroke, resulting in a composition of near perfection. Cézanne constructed form and volume using color alone—he did not model his shapes by shading with lighter to darker values to create a sense of 3D. Instead, he used brushstrokes in dense combinations of opaque paint in a narrow spectrum of colors. Cool tones (blue, black, gray) that make up the tablecloth contrast with the warm tones (red, yellow, orange) that make up the fruit. Yellows, oranges, reds and greens reflect across and seemingly melt into the flesh of the fruit and in more softened shades penetrate the surface of the jug. Cézanne recognized a universal geometry fundamental to all objects, claiming that nature could be understood as a construction of three basic shapes: the cylinder, sphere and cone. The fruit and white plate and jug on the tabletop and the caned chair behind the table on the right are constructed of these basic shapes.

Revision History

Revision Date	Docent Name	Comments
1983	Nancy Marston, Dana James and Karen Drucker	Developed
1999	Committee lead by Bonnie Sorenson	Revision
2005	Committee lead by Clara Krispie	Option of artificial or fresh fruits and veggies
November 2011	Committee lead by Elena Shea	Simplify still life arrangement, take out inking step
February 2013	Curriculum Committee	Added suggestions for docents to give feedback to children
September 2014	Curriculum Committee	Lesson broken into 2 part lesson – drawing/inking and painting
October 2014	Kimberly Dickerson	Reviewed after teaching it in 2 parts and minor adjustments made.
May 2015	Elena Shea	Simplified introduction to include only Cezanne. Removed drawing of pattern in ink (this will be handled in 2 nd lesson with paint).
October 2016	Yasmin Braun	Added white erasers to unit
May 2019	Kimberly Dickerson	New VAPA Standards added
February 2023	Kimberly Dickerson	Additional prints added to introduction for principles of design discussion.